

Episode 58: Once Upon a Time... (39) – Summer Vacation, "School Pool," and "Television Manga"

The other day when I tried to buy tea from a vending machine, "Clank! Clink!" - the 100 yen coin I inserted came back to the change slot. "Maybe I didn't insert it properly?" I tried again. "Clank! Clink!" - it came back again.

"Ah, I see."

This 100 yen coin was genuine, but its surface had worn down considerably, and even the feel when pinched between fingers was like "thin? ...maybe?" So the vending machine rejected it. Looking closely, this 100 yen coin had "Showa 49" engraved on the surface. Showa 49 (1974) - a 100 yen coin minted when I was in 5th grade. Ah, it's been working for over 30 years since it was made.

Curious, I checked the other small change in my pocket. And found even older coins!

A 50 yen coin from Showa 42 (1967), one 100 yen coin each, and a 100 yen from Showa 47 (1972). There was also a 100 yen from Showa 50 (1975). Ah, coins are surprisingly aged.

Among all the small change in my pocket, that "Showa 49" 100 yen coin was the most worn and shabby. The older Showa 42 100 yen coin looked cleaner and more solid, appearing younger and newer.

It's kind of like humans.

I wondered what experiences that worn "Showa 49" 100 yen coin had been through.

I bought that vending machine tea with a still-young "Heisei 3" (1991) 100 yen coin (laugh).

Well then.

Next week, children and students will plunge into summer vacation.

When I was still in elementary school, some 30-plus years ago, one of summer vacation's pleasures was none other than "Television Manga." We didn't say "anime" yet, did we? Not "anime" but "Television Manga."

During summer vacation, from late July through August, Tokyo's Channel 10 - NET (now TV Asahi) - had "Television Manga" broadcast time during weekday mornings. "Summer Vacation Manga Festival" or something like that was the program title. About an hour-long slot starting around 10 AM.

What did they show? American-made animations like *Wacky Races* (チキチキマシン猛レース), *King Kong*, *Tom Thumb*, and *Super 3*, plus reruns of *Magic User Sally* (魔法使いサリー) and *Pyun Pyun Maru* (ぴゅんぴゅん丸). I looked forward to it so much and watched voraciously.

My elementary school summer vacation routine: first, wake up at 6 AM (be woken up (laugh)), go to radio exercises at the nearby middle school playground to get my stamp, eat breakfast, then be made to help with garden cleaning, then sit at my desk briefly to do summer homework arithmetic drills until "Television Manga" time. In the afternoon I'd run around the neighbourhood chasing cicadas with a bug net, or ride my bicycle around aimlessly (laugh).

And into this life came the troublesome thing called "school pool." Different days, morning or afternoon, schedules organised by grade level - it wasn't absolutely mandatory, but I almost always went (was made to go). Well, if you went, some friend

would be there, and splashing around in the water was somewhat fun... but actually, I was quite bad at swimming (bitter laugh).

So having to give up enjoyable "Television Manga" to go to "school pool" that I didn't even like much felt somehow unreasonable to a child's heart (bitter laugh). Oh dear (bitter laugh).

Back then there were still quite a few anime rerun slots in the evening time slots too, and I watched plenty of anime normally outside summer vacation, but being able to watch anime during time when I'd usually be at school was what was good about it (laugh).

Moreover, this summer vacation slot had a slightly different lineup tendency from the evening shows. *Wacky Races* and *Pyun Pyun Maru* were repeated every summer vacation and were consistently good as standards. Thinking about it, maybe there weren't that many domestic anime available for reruns back then? How was it?

Recently anime broadcast slots have completely changed, with unthinkable early morning weekend slots and late night becoming anime time. Plus there are basically no reruns anymore (oh, there's *Gundam 00* late night (laugh)).

But I'd really like to watch "Television Manga" again now. I want to show today's children *Wacky Races* and *Tom Thumb*. And I'd like to make such anime.

Recently, when I looked down from a Chuo Line train, I saw elementary school pool classes in session. Watching the frolicking children made me think such things.

Tokyo's rainy season is almost over.

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